

ONE THING LED TO ANOTHER

“How did you end up here?”

It sounds like a simple question until you try to answer it properly.

Not here as in the chair you’re sitting in, the job that takes up so much of your day, the town you now call home. Here as in the life you’re standing in now. The people still beside you. The ones who aren’t. The work you stayed with, the place you left, the number you still recognise even though you deleted the name years ago.

The easy answer is that one thing led to another.

Which is true. It’s also fairly useless.

One thing always leads to another. The difficult part is working out which things mattered. At the time, they rarely announce themselves. There’s no shift in the lighting when you make a decision that will follow you for years. No ominous music when someone takes back their key, you accept that lift, take the job, stay for one more drink or decide not to make the phone call when you probably should have. Usually, it’s just an ordinary day continuing to behave like one.

You don’t know that something is a beginning while you’re standing in it. It might look like a spare mattress, a borrowed uniform, a half-packed bag or a name written on the back of a receipt because neither of you has your phone handy. Beginnings are inconsiderate like that. They arrive looking like nothing much, then expect to be recognised years later when half the details have gone missing.

Endings are generally not any more helpful. Some make themselves obvious. There’s shouting, a door slams, someone drives away. Others happen so quietly that you carry on for months without realising something has already finished. You keep an old key on the ring. Leave a number in your phone. Tell people you’ll go back when things settle down, as though life has ever shown the slightest interest in settling down for your convenience.

You might have no wish to go back and still remember how someone laughed before they could get the words out. How you could look across a table and know you were both trying not to. There was a time when something happening to you meant having something to tell them. You can miss that person, know that calling wouldn't make anything better and still grieve what you thought it would become. Saying it didn't work out is accurate enough. It leaves a fair bit out of what did.

Later, you make a story from what remains.

You choose the parts that still make sense. Leave out the names that require too much explanation. Move quickly over the years when nothing seemed to change, even though you now understand that plenty was happening underneath. You give certain decisions more thought than they received at the time. This is generous of you. It allows the person you used to be to appear almost organised.

That person probably appreciates the help.

They had enough to deal with already: getting through the week, covering the rent, waiting for someone to call, hoping someone else wouldn't. Maybe they were trying to hold together a relationship everybody could see was finished. Maybe they were telling themselves a job was temporary because admitting they had no better idea felt worse. Maybe they were doing well and still lying awake at two in the morning, convinced they had somehow wandered into another person's life and would be asked to leave as soon as anyone noticed.

Or perhaps they were happy. Properly happy. Those years exist too, although memory can be strangely careless with them. Misery leaves paperwork. Happiness might leave nothing more than an old photograph in which nobody is looking at the camera because whatever was happening beyond the frame seemed more important.

Friendships have their own short versions. We were close. We lost touch. You can say that without mentioning the friend you could tell almost anything, provided you didn't mind hearing it repeated. Or the one you kept making excuses for because, when things were good, nobody made you laugh like they did. Perhaps you knew which subjects to avoid,

which promises not to rely on. Sometimes you loved someone you could no longer trust.

And there may be someone you haven't spoken to for months whose number you'd still ring when things go wrong. You wouldn't have to begin with an apology for leaving it so long. They'd ask where you were, and whether you wanted them to come.

Now you know more. That's your unfair advantage.

From here, you can sometimes hear the warning inside a conversation you thought was ordinary. You know who was trying to help, who was full of shit and, if you're being honest, how often those turned out to be the same person. You can identify the moment you should have left and the reason you stayed. You may even understand the person you blamed.

You can name what someone did to you. The harder question is what someone else would say you did to them. In the version you tell, the argument may begin at the point where they became unreasonable. Asked what happened before that, you'd need a longer answer. Their version may include the moment you stopped trying to make your point and started trying to make it hurt. There may be a sentence you barely remember saying that someone else could still repeat exactly, including the way you said it.

Understanding someone doesn't necessarily mean forgiving them. Sometimes the older you looks back with tenderness. Sometimes with embarrassment. Occasionally with the strong desire to reach through time, grab yourself by the shoulders and ask what the fuck you thought you were doing.

Sometimes you were doing your best. Sometimes you knew exactly what you were doing and wanted it badly enough to carry on. There are things you couldn't have known. There are also things you knew and hoped wouldn't matter.

Being able to explain a choice does not make it a good one. It does make it part of the truth.

Perhaps that is why the shortest answers can feel slightly dishonest even when every word is accurate. They tell people where you went without saying what carried you there. They turn confusion into direction, accidents into decisions and survival into something resembling a plan. They remove

the wasted time, the false starts and the years you spent insisting you knew exactly what you were doing.

From far enough away, almost any life can be made to look deliberate.

Most conversations don't leave much room for the fuller account. Someone asks, you give them the version that fits, and they offer something of their own. Fair enough. There's food coming, someone has to leave, and you weren't planning to explain ten years of your life between ordering and the bill.

But suppose they stay with it. Remember the name you mentioned. Ask why you went back, or what you liked about someone you've only described badly. You reach the usual end of the story and they haven't begun telling theirs. There's a pause you would normally fill with a joke.

Given the time, and the nerve to use it, you might find yourself saying that isn't quite how it happened. The person you've been blaming did come through for you once. You were happy there before you were miserable. You didn't leave for the reason you usually give. Each correction means going back a little further, bringing in someone you left out, allowing a good memory to sit beside one you'd rather not have.

What seemed too ordinary to bother telling begins to take time. A name needs explaining. So does a decision that sounds ridiculous until you remember what the other option was. You can spend years thinking there's nothing much to say about your life, then find yourself halfway through an answer with the person listening asking what happened next.

Telling it means standing beside earlier versions of yourself without letting them rewrite what happened and without punishing them for everything they could not yet know. The person making those choices did not think of themselves as your younger self. They were the finished version. You were the one who didn't exist yet.

Perhaps a name has already come to mind. Someone you'd have to go back and explain before you could answer the question properly. They might hardly appear in the version most people know.

I'll need to introduce a few people too.

The names and places from here will be mine. So will the choices. I know what came next. The person living it didn't have a fucking clue.